



Critical Thinking and Debate

Spring, 2026

Course No.	HA2310	Course Title	Critical Thinking and Debate	Hours Classroom	3 Credits Seminar Rm. Darwin
Instructor	Young Mee Kim (kimyoungmee@ksa.ha.kr) Office: 3301			Office Hours	Wed 1, Thu 2-3

I. Course Description

The *Critical Thinking and Debate* course is designed to implement a competency-based teaching and learning approach that promotes both academic preparedness and real-world applicability. With a strong emphasis on advanced English proficiency, the course aims to develop students' cognitive strategies, argumentation skills, and academic literacy. Students will engage in intellectually challenging activities that foster independent thinking, evidence-based reasoning, and collaborative dialogue. Through the exploration of diverse cultural and academic topics, advanced-level English-speaking students will expand their analytical abilities and broaden their global perspectives.

II. Course Objectives

By the end of the course, students will be able to:

- Actively engage in shaping their own learning through inquiry and reflection
- Connect academic learning with personal interests, values, and long-term goals
- Demonstrate mastery of content and communication in a performance-based context
- Apply critical and creative thinking, abstract reasoning, and logical argumentation
- Participate effectively in academic debates, presenting evidence-based perspectives
- Become self-directed, reflective learners who can evaluate their own progress and adapt strategies for improvement

III. Class Materials

- **Textbook:** Laurie Blass & Mari Vargo (2017). *Pathways 4: Reading, Writing, and Critical Thinking*. (2nd ed.) NGL/ Cengage Learning. ISBN: 978-1-337-62513-5
- **Supplementary Materials:** A variety of audiovisual materials, including TED Talks, academic articles, opinion editorials, and sample debate videos, will be used to support class discussions and assignments.
- **Tools:** Students are required to bring a laptop or tablet for writing, research and in-class activities. All written assignments will be submitted via Google Docs.

IV. Evaluation Criteria

➤ **Midterm Exam (30%)**

The midterm exam is designed to evaluate students' understanding of key course materials and their ability to apply personal insight and critical thinking through academic writing and vocabulary development.

➤ **Final Presentation (20%)**

The final project will be an in-class presentation in which students will explore a theme of their choice by integrating creative insight and critical thinking. Presentations should demonstrate original interpretation, thoughtful analysis, and clear organization. Detailed instructions and evaluation criteria will be provided in class.

➤ **Article Review (20%)**

Students will be required to construct a personalized learning schema, engage in critical thinking activities and submit a critical article review based on a selected topic from the course. This assignment is designed to assess students' ability to analyze, synthesize, and express critical ideas clearly and effectively. Further details and guidelines will be provided in class.

➤ **Class Participation (20%)**

Active participation is essential in this course, which emphasizes a competency-based approach to promote learner autonomy. Students are expected to contribute meaningfully to class discussions and debates, come prepared with assigned materials, and complete all workshop-related tasks in a timely and thoughtful manner.

➤ **Attendance (10%)**

Attendance is assessed based on students' consistent presence and punctuality in each class session. Unexcused absences and repeated tardiness will result in significant grade deductions.

◆ **Attendance and Evaluation Guidelines:**

- Criterion-referenced grading will be prioritized over norm-referenced grading to ensure that student performance is evaluated according to clearly defined learning outcomes.
- In the case of absence from the midterm exam, the average score of the semester's performance assessments will be converted proportionally
- For details regarding the percentage of credit points applied, please refer to the Academic Performance Management Regulations.
- If the course instructor deems it necessary, a separate written examination for absent students may be administered following consultation with the Humanity Committee.
- Students must attend at least three-quarters ($\frac{3}{4}$) of the total class hours to be eligible for credit.
- Attendance Deductions:
 - Unexcused absence (without prior notice or permission): -0.5 points
(includes absence due to sickness without notice)
- Tardiness exceeding 10 minutes or negatively affecting participation: -0.2 points

V. Class Policies

Academic integrity is essential to this course. Plagiarism, cheating, and any form of academic dishonesty are strictly prohibited. Students are fully responsible for the quality and integrity of their own work. Any violation will result in an automatic zero for the assignment, referral to school authorities, and notification of the student's academic advisor. Upholding academic honesty is vital to maintaining a community of trust in the classroom.

VI. Tentative Course Schedule

Week	Content	Skill Focus	Competency Focus
1	Course Introduction & Learning Design	Self-Management Goal setting	Intrinsic Motivation & Self-Directed Learning
2	Chapter Journal & Debate	Reading & Interpretation Vocabulary development Oral Communication & Debate Reasoning & Problem-Solving Cultural Literacy	Extensive ideas Open-Mindedness & Cultural Intelligence Elaborated communication Academic rigor Collaboration & Teamwork Analytical & Logical Thinking Ethics & Academic Standards
3	Chapter Journal & Debate		
4	Chapter Journal & Debate		
5	Chapter Journal & Debate		
6	Chapter Journal & Debate		
7	Essay prompt writing	Writing & Composition	Academic Rigor & Integrity
8	<i>Midterm Exams</i>		

Project 1: Final Presentation

9	Introduction/ Outline	Presentation & Delivery Skills Public speaking Critique	Leadership & Influence Convergence reasoning Confidence & motivation Innovation & Applied Creativity
10~12	Presentation/Discussion/ Feedback		

Project 2: Article Review

13	Introduction/ Outline	Research skills Critical review Scientific writing & composition Revision Editing & Improvement Research & Information Literacy	Proactive exploration Intensive intelligence Critical thinking Academic perseverance Academic culture & integrity Creative-productive thinking Persistence & Adaptability
14	Article Review Drafting		
15	Peer Editing/ Revision		
16	Paper submission & Consolidation		
17	Final Exams		

- The instructor may adjust the schedule as deemed appropriate.
- The class can go online in the case of the inevitable state of affairs.
- Chapter journal may be completed either in pairs or individually, while the article review and presentation will be completed individually.

➤ Skill Focus – Expanded

- **Academic Reading & Analysis:**
comprehension of complex texts, extracting key arguments, evaluating sources
- **Vocabulary Development:**
discipline-specific terminology, academic collocations, idiomatic expressions
- **Discussion & Debate:**
structured argumentation, rebuttal techniques, evidence-based persuasion
- **Research Skills:**
identifying credible sources, synthesizing literature, citation management
- **Critical & Creative Thinking:**
divergent thinking, problem reframing, solution design
- **Scientific Writing:**
clarity, coherence, formal tone, logical progression
- **Revision & Editing:**
peer review, self-editing, iterative improvement
- **Public Speaking:**
vocal clarity, audience engagement, persuasive delivery
- **Digital Literacy:**
responsible AI use, online collaboration tools, multimodal communication

➤ Competency Focus – Expanded

- **Intrinsic Motivation & Self-Directed Learning:**
goal setting, self-assessment, autonomous decision-making
- **Open-Mindedness & Cultural Intelligence:**
respectful dialogue, cross-cultural perspectives, adaptability
- **Academic Rigor & Integrity:**
ethical scholarship, source transparency, quality assurance
- **Collaboration & Teamwork:**
shared responsibility, constructive feedback, consensus-building
- **Analytical & Convergent Reasoning:**
logical deduction, evidence evaluation, synthesis of ideas
- **Creative-Productive Thinking:**
original solutions, innovative approaches, practical application
- **Global Leadership & Communication:**
influence through dialogue, intercultural negotiation
- **Resilience & Perseverance:**
handling constructive criticism, managing challenges, sustaining focus